

HOUSE No. 4419

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES, September 8, 2025.

The committee on Agriculture and Fisheries, to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by resolve, House, No. 118) of Mindy Domb and Andres X. Vargas for an investigation by a special commission (including members of the General Court) relative to the sustainability of eligible emergency food providers, known as food pantries, reports recommending that the accompanying resolve (House, No. 4419) ought to pass.

For the committee,

NATALIE M. BLAIS.

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**In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)**

Resolve providing for an investigation by a special commission relative to the strengths and sustainability of the Commonwealth's emergency food network.

1 **Resolved**, that a special commission is hereby established to study the sustainability of
2 eligible emergency food providers, known as food pantries, in the Massachusetts Emergency
3 Food Assistance Program (MEFAP). The commission shall study the strengths of food pantry
4 programs and the challenges they face regarding the adequacy of state support, workforce
5 development, organizational sustainability, governance, succession planning, and capacity to
6 meet resident needs.

7 Resolved, that the commission shall make recommendations to address the capacity of
8 the emergency food network, specifically the network of food pantries, regarding: (i) workforce
9 development, training, apprenticeship opportunities, (ii) policies and technical assistance to
10 support organizational sustainability, governance and succession planning, (iii) assessment of
11 emergency food needed to meet the commonwealth's demand, (iv) implications of increased
12 need on projected purchasing and impact on state funding and private fundraising, and (v) the
13 frequency of food pantry use by Massachusetts residents.

14 Resolved, the commission shall consist of: the commissioner of the Massachusetts
15 department of agricultural resources or a designee, who shall serve as chair; the commissioner of
16 the department of transitional assistance or a designee; a member of the Massachusetts food
17 system caucus to be appointed by the chairs of the caucus; a member who shall be appointed by
18 the speaker; a member who shall be appointed by the senate president; a representative of the
19 merrimack valley food bank; a representative of the greater boston food bank; a representative
20 from the worcester county food bank; a representative of the food bank of western
21 Massachusetts; 4 representatives from food pantries appointed by the food bank coalition of
22 Massachusetts, 1 of whom shall represent a food pantry operating in an urban area, 1 of whom
23 shall represent a food pantry operating in a suburban area, 1 of whom shall represent a food
24 pantry operating in a rural area, and 1 of whom shall represent a food pantry operating in a non-
25 urban area; and 2 representatives who shall be participants in food pantry programs from diverse
26 cultural, racial, social, geographic or ethnic backgrounds appointed by the Massachusetts food
27 system collaborative.

28 The commission shall ensure that its meetings shall be open to the public, notes will be
29 taken and made available. The appointment of the commissioners shall occur within 30 days
30 after the effective date of this resolve. The commission shall convene its first meeting no later
31 than 45 days after the bill's enactment. The commission shall meet as often as needed to
32 complete its report.

33 Within 18 months of enactment, the commission shall file a report of its findings and
34 recommendations, together with drafts of legislation necessary to carry those recommendations
35 into effect by filing the same to the clerks of the house of representatives and senate, the chairs
36 of the joint committee on agriculture and fisheries, the chairs of the joint committee on children,

37 families, and persons with disabilities; and the chairs of the joint committee on aging and
38 independence on the results of its investigation and its recommendations, including proposals of
39 legislation or regulations necessary to carry its recommendations into effect.

40 The commission shall dissolve 30 days after the submission of the report, unless upon a
41 two-thirds vote of the commission, a continuance is deemed necessary to complete the purpose
42 of the commission. The time frame of said continuance must be specified in the motion to extend
43 time of operation.